

2006 Islamic Courts Union takes the capital, Mogadishu, and brings some order to the country. Ethiopian troops and US gunships intervene to attack the Islamists, who flee in 2007.

2007 African Union forces arrive in Somalia.

2008 Somali-based pirates hijack Saudi Arabian oil supertanker *MV Sirius Star*.

2009 Radical Islamist group Al-Shabbab makes gains as Ethiopian army withdraws.

Kenya



A diverse nation of 70 different peoples, Kenya has had a difficult post-colonial history.

1200 A distinctive Swahili culture of mixed Arabs, Africans, and Persians thrives on the coast, while Bantu, Cushitic, and Nilotic speakers live inland.

1498 Portuguese explorer Vasco da Gama visits the powerful city of Mombasa.

1502–09 Portuguese take over Swahili ports on the coast.

1698 Omanis from the Arabian peninsula control the entire coast, moving their capital from Muscat to Zanzibar in 1840.

1920 Kenya becomes a British colony.

1944 Kenyan African Union (KAU) formed. Jomo Kenyatta leads it from 1947.

1952–56 Mau Mau, Kikuyu-led violent campaign to restore African lands.

1953 KAU banned and Kenyatta is jailed until 1961, when he is released and takes up the presidency of KANU.

1963 Independence. The following year a republic is set up. Kenyatta is president and Odinga vice president.

1969 Jaramogi Mboya murdered, Odinga arrested as opposition to KANU grows.

1978 Kenyatta dies: vice president Daniel arap Moi succeeds him.

1990 Government implicated in deaths of foreign minister Robert Ouko and Anglican archbishop. Riots. Odinga and others form FORD, outlawed by government.

1991 Arrest of FORD leaders and attempts to stop prodemocracy protests.

1997 December, Moi wins further term in widely criticized elections.

1999 Moi appoints paleontologist Richard Leakey to lead drive against corruption; Leakey resigns in 2001.

2002 Mwai Kibaki becomes first non-KANU president on promise to end corruption. Corruption worsens.

2005 Violent protesters in Nairobi reject proposed new constitution.

2008 Tribal violence kills over 1,000 after a disputed presidential election. Power-sharing agreement between president Mwai Kibaki and Raile Odinga.

2010 Referendum passes constitutional changes to limit presidential authority and devolve more power to the regions.

◀182–83 South of the Sahara
◀412–13 End of the Colonial Era

Uganda



A country on the East African Plateau torn apart by ethnic strife and bad government.

1700s Buganda replaces Bunyoro as the major kingdom in the region.

1890 The UK and Germany agree that Buganda is of interest to the UK, and Tanganyika to Germany.

1894 A British protectorate is established over Buganda. Bunyoro, Toro, Ankole, and Busoga follow in 1896.

1953–55 The Kabaka of Buganda, Mutesa II, is exiled to the UK for opposing British plans for a unitary state.

1962 Uganda is independent, with Milton Obote as prime minister and the Kabaka as head of state.

1962–71 Milton Obote in power.

1966 New constitution ends Buganda's autonomy; in 1967 traditional kingships are abolished; the Kabaka goes into exile.

1971 Idi Amin seizes power in a military coup; he expels the Asian community in 1972, leading to economic collapse. After he invades Tanzania in 1978 to claim new territory, Tanzania invades Uganda in 1979 and ends his brutal rule.

1980–85 Milton Obote returns to rule the country for a second time. Yoweri Museveni sets up National Resistance Army to overthrow Obote.

1986 Museveni seizes power and establishes the “no party” system that removes ethnic clashes from politics.

1993 Traditional kingships restored.

1996 Museveni wins first free presidential election.

1999 Agreement with Sudan allows troops to enter Sudan in pursuit of rebel Lord's Resistance Army (LRA) fighters.

2002 Uganda withdraws its forces after intervening in Congo's civil war.

2006 Government and LRA sign truce aimed at ending long-running conflict.

2008 Government and LRA sign a ceasefire, but fighting continues.

2010 Bomb attacks in Kampala kill 74 people. The Somali Islamist militia Al-Shabbab claims responsibility.

◀412–13 End of the Colonial Era

Tanzania



A peaceful but poor nation with a strong Swahili culture and tradition.

800s Arab merchants establish a trading settlement at Kilwa, while Persian merchants settle on Zanzibar and Pemba.

1200 A distinctive Swahili culture of Arabs, Africans, and Persians thrives.

1500–09 Portuguese take over Swahili ports on the coast.

1650s Omanis take over Zanzibar; it eventually becomes the capital of their maritime empire in 1840.

1873 The UK forces the Sultan of Zanzibar to close his slave market.

1885 Tanganyika a German colony; the British take over Zanzibar in 1890.

1919 Tanganyika a British mandate.

1961 Tanganyika independent, followed by Zanzibar in 1963.

1962 Julius Nyerere becomes president and introduces policy of African socialism.

1964 Sultanate of Zanzibar overthrown in left-wing revolution; Tanganyika and Zanzibar merge to become Tanzania.

1985 President Mwinyi begins relaxation of socialist policies after Nyerere retires.

1995 Multi-party elections. Benjamin Mkapa becomes president.

2005 Jakaya Kikwete wins presidency.

2010 Tanzania joins the new East African Common Market.

Rwanda



An ethnically divided country and the scene of an appalling act of genocide in 1994.

1000s Arrival of Hutu agriculturalists, followed by Tutsi cattle-owners in 1400s. They remain distinct ethnic groups.

1897 Traditional kingdom of Rwanda is absorbed into German East Africa.

1922 Belgium takes over Rwanda from Germany under mandate.



Rwandan crisis

Within 100 days in 1994 some 800,000 Tutsis were murdered by Hutu militias. The militias then fled to neighboring Zaire, taking with them about 2 million Hutu refugees (above).

1962 Independence under a Hutu-led government.

1994 Hutu president Habyarimana dies in plane crash blamed on Tutsis. Genocidal violence killing 800,000 people is then unleashed by Hutu extremists against Tutsis and moderate Hutus.

2000 Paul Kagame is elected president.

2005 Mass release of 36,000 prisoners who have confessed to the genocide.

2008 Paul Kagame's RPF wins elections.

2009 Rwanda's education system switches from French to English. Rwanda is admitted to the Commonwealth.

Burundi



A small nation torn between its Hutu majority and dominant Tutsi minority peoples.

1897 Burundi kingdom absorbed into German East Africa.

1922 Belgium takes over. Country is merged with Rwanda as Ruanda-Urundi.

1959 Split from Rwanda is followed by independence from Belgium in 1962.

1966 Army overthrows monarchy.

1972 Tutsis massacre 150,000 Hutus.

1993 Ndadaye, the first Hutu president, is killed in Tutsi-dominated army coup.

2000 Arusha peace accord between Tutsis and Hutus, power-sharing agreed.

2003 Major rebel assault against Bujumbura as power-sharing deal falters.

2005 A new power-sharing constitution.

2008–09 Renewed fighting between government forces and FNL rebels.